

2, What Factors in Japanese History Favored Feudalization?

Regarding the historical process of the *Samurai* rising to power and seizing the regime, Japanese scholars have already researched it in exhaustive detail. Building upon their foundation, I will record here what I consider to be the favorable factors that emerged during Japan's *feudalization* process.

First, although Japan prematurely introduced the *restoration-bureaucratic system* from China, it was indeed far too early for Japan. The emperor lacked the conditions to unleash the true potency of this despotic polity because, at that time, Japan's clan aristocrats remained powerful; it was far from the decaying scene of a class-transition phase.

This meant that the emperor's actual power in state politics was inevitably checked and constrained by the bureaucratized aristocracy. Nothing represents this situation better than the *Sekkan Seiji* (摄关政治 / Regency politics) of the mid-Heian period.

As a result, even though the Japanese emperors attempted to enhance their power using the Chinese system, its despotic color (*at least from my perspective as a Chinese person*) was simply too faint.

Despotism (专制) and bureaucracy (官僚) are two concepts inextricably linked. To strengthen his despotic power, a despotic ruler cannot do without a complex **bureaucratic system** to co-opt, divide, and suppress strata that might pose a threat. Conversely, the more powerful the bureaucratic system (*in the eyes of Chinese, a purely "official-centric" / 官本位 society*), the more powerful the despotic power becomes.

This phenomenon is very easy to understand in China. Because power is only responsible to its source, and in a bureaucratic society, members' socio-economic status heavily depends on their position within the bureaucratic system—where their power is derived from superiors—if one traces this upward layer by layer, state power will inevitably be monopolized in the hands of an absolute few.

Since the ancient Japanese emperors did not possess such strong despotic coloration, Japan's bureaucratic system was consequently weakened, because the Japanese had no need, unlike the Chinese, to ultimately be responsible to a single emperor. Japan's *Ritsuryō* reforms did not merely expand the emperor's power; powerful clans represented by the Fujiwara likewise expanded their interests nationwide by virtue of their expansion within the bureaucratic system. This meant that the *Ritsuryō* reforms did not exclusively benefit the monarch alone.

In fact, when observing Japan, many people only see the emperor being of an "*unbroken imperial line for ages eternal*" (万世一系), but easily overlook that the *Kuge*—whose ranks were determined by their family status (家格)—also accompanied the imperial system from beginning to end.

Therefore, it was impossible for the emperor to lord over the masses and "*decide the affairs of the realm with a single word*" (一言以决天下事) like his Chinese counterparts. Although endowed with unparalleled divinity, in practical politics, he was merely the "**aristocrat among aristocrats**"—the one with the highest rank among a multitude of nobles.

A relationship of competition and confrontation still existed between the emperor and the aristocratic *Kuge*, which created a relatively friendly environment for the rise of the *Samurai*. Not

only did the *Samurai* avoid becoming public enemies right from the start, but they were also able to profit from both sides to strengthen themselves.

(Here it must be emphasized that although Japan's Heian period and China's Southern Dynasties both appear to be dynastic states where aristocrats occupied vital positions, their natures were fundamentally different. The aristocrats of the Heian period originated from the clan aristocrats initially formed since class differentiation; however, the so-called aristocrats of the Six Dynasties in Jiangzuo / 江左六朝 were themselves massive landowners formed since **feudalization**, as China's clan aristocrats had already been largely annihilated during the Qin-Han transition).

Due to the lack of a history of strong despotism, the Japanese cared very much about "public consensus" (公论). This inertia of adopting collegial deliberation (合议) in decision-making evidently favored the unfolding of **feudalization**.

When reading the history of the Heian dynasty, one thing left a profound impression on me: the Japanese always meticulously and methodically considered the rights and responsibilities of any given matter. This is unimaginable for a resident like me, living in a society under prolonged bureaucratic rule.

Although official laws of various dynasties in China were not entirely heedless of the equivalence between rights and obligations, in China, who genuinely takes principles seriously? Even in today's news, ambiguous phrasing like "*relevant authorities*" (有关部门) remains rampantly popular, yet surprisingly, the vast majority of the billion-plus souls do not find it strange.

The clear equivalence of power and responsibility should undoubtedly be one of the foremost political principles. But once power is concentrated in the hands of an individual despot, even the simplest logic makes it clear that this principle will inevitably be impossible to execute.

Because even if there is no upper limit to the power a single person can exercise, the responsibility they can bear is always finite. The emperors of China would mutter, "*If there are sins in the myriad regions, the sin rests on my person alone*" (万方有罪，罪在朕躬); Emperor Chongzhen (Zhu Youjian) issued edicts of self-condemnation (罪己诏) six times in the 17 years before the fall of his state. Yet, let alone genuinely punishing themselves, if they simply continued to act willfully, who could do anything about it?

Thus, in the final years of the Chinese Empire, power became increasingly concentrated at the top, while responsibilities were increasingly distributed at the bottom. **When speaking of benefits, the common people disappeared; when discussing costs, not a single one was spared.** This is what inevitably occurs when despotic bureaucratic totalitarianism develops to a certain degree.

When the taxation logic of the mid-Heian Japanese court shifted, it is genuinely inconceivable to me how smoothly and explicitly rights and obligations fell upon the shoulders of the *Zuryō* (contract governors) and *Fumyō* (named taxpayers). It is evident that in Japan, the bureaucratic system did not destroy fundamental political principles, and this too alleviated the difficulties the *Samurai* faced in seizing power.

Second, the rise and fall of the *Ritsuryō* state possessed a distinct "time lag" (时差) compared to Japan's own historical trajectory. This refers to the point mentioned earlier: classical Japan in the typical sense was actually only the *Insei* (Cloistered Rule) era of the late Heian period. Yet, by the

end of the 11th century CE—when *Insei* stepped onto the historical stage as a political model—Japan's *Ritsuryō* system had, in fact, long existed in name only.

Although I harbor an extremely approving attitude toward the magnificent achievements of the *Samurai*, I must admit that while the statement "*the Samurai defeated the aristocratic bureaucrats in a feudal revolution*" is formally correct, in specific terms, it was not the *Samurai* who forced the *Ritsuryō* system to its dead end. The rise of the *Samurai* occurred later than the collapse of the *Ritsuryō* system.

The logic behind this is not complicated. The very birth of the *Ritsuryō* system in China was originally the stress response of the monarch and the **bureaucratic system** against **feudal lords** (封建领主). Even as a type of bureaucratic system, it was inherently immature, and it was even impossible for it not to possess certain characteristics of a **feudalized** (封建化的) era—such as the aforementioned government directly controlling and distributing the means of production (i.e., the Equal-field system).

Once this naive fantasy was transplanted to Japan, the situation became even more bizarre. The Japanese court now also intended to implement the *Kōchi-Kōmin* system (公民公地制 / system of public land and public citizens), but its stage of social development could not possibly produce a sufficient number of **detached bureaucrats** (脱产官僚) to keep the policies operational, as the Tang Dynasty had.

No matter how infinitely powerful a policy appears, executing it practically ultimately requires human hands. In the 7th and 8th centuries CE, the only entities within Japan capable of formally accomplishing this task were the powerful aristocrats, like the Fujiwara clan.

Since the task of distributing the means of production had to be accomplished through these powerful aristocrats, it was fundamentally impossible for the court—or the emperor—to prevent them from encroaching upon the land. Under such circumstances, the *Ritsuryō* state actually accelerated the formation and expansion of feudal manors (庄园).

The manors owned by the imperial family, aristocrats, and major temples/shrines (寺社) were massive in number and widely distributed. These exalted manor lords (庄园主) had neither the willingness nor the capability to manage and maintain them. The *Samurai* stepped onto the stage as the personnel handling manor affairs for these noblemen and famous temples.

Therefore, when the *Samurai* moved to the forefront of history, their identity was that of **collaborators** with the power-holders, not **antagonists**. This point is extremely worthy of note. Although the *Samurai* are ultimately remembered by posterity as Japan's **feudal lords**, the people who could originally be termed "**feudal lords**" in Japan were perhaps precisely those manor lords who were eventually replaced by the *Samurai* in the long river of history.

Third, throughout the Heian period, Japan's external geopolitical situation was highly favorable to **feudalization**.

Exhausted from coping with a gradually collapsing frontier situation and frontier warlords (藩镇 / *Fanzhen*) slipping out of control following the An Lushan Rebellion, the Tang Empire could no longer pose any realistic threat to Japan.

By the time the Song Dynasty was established, the further consolidation of the **bureaucratic system** resulted in the people of the Chinese Empire replacing any foreign ethnic group as the greatest imaginary enemy of the Chinese rulers. This transformation was manifested in the diplomatic realm as a gradual conservatism; it was impossible for the empire to frequently launch interventionist and expansionist wars as it had during the Han and Tang dynasties.

Ever since the state of Balhae (渤海国), the economy of China's Northeast region further developed, and newly rising ethnic minority regimes continuously established themselves or expanded into this area. Clashing with Korean regimes expanding northward, the Koreans were also forced to shift their military focus to the north.

For an island nation suspended overseas like Japan, these changes in circumstances undoubtedly meant a massive alleviation of military pressure, thereby providing the conditions for the massive disarmament during the Heian period when "*peace prevailed at home and abroad*" (中外无事). The situation of universal peace not only rendered the *Ritsuryō* state's extraction of manpower and wealth utterly unjustifiable, but also handed the task of domestic "security wars" (治安战争) over to the newly rising *Samurai*.

However, this low-intensity warfare did not mean a complete absence of war. For the majority of the Heian period, Japan consistently strengthened its control over the Tohoku (东北) region, and the conquest of the Emishi (虾夷) existed as a long-term enterprise.

Looking back in hindsight, as opponents of the Japanese regime, the strength of the Emishi was absolutely perfect. They were neither so strong that defeating them required massive military mobilization capabilities, nor so weak that a few dozen or a hundred pioneer settlers could waltz in as if entering an unpopulated land. If the Japanese court was to cope with the war against the Emishi, its most effective and low-cost option was to rely on the *Samurai*.

For the *Samurai*, the Emishi were neither so strong as to be utterly invincible or require an exorbitant price for victory, nor so weak that a mere armed parade would secure an immediate triumph. The reality is that the *Samurai* were thoroughly tempered and hardened in the wars against the Emishi. They not only learned combat techniques from their opponents—for instance, the later world-renowned *Katana* (武士刀) evolved from the weapons of the Emishi—but it was precisely during these protracted battles that the master-vassal relationships (主从关系) inherent to the *Samurai* were forged, and the prestige of the Minamoto clan as the "*Head of the Warrior Houses*" (武家栋梁) was established.

It was also in war that land-based rewards for meritorious service (恩赏) began to form, and the self-awareness of the *Samurai* awoke. In the domestic wars and the Emishi subjugation campaigns centered around the Kanto (关东) and Tohoku regions, the power of local *Samurai* bands continuously expanded, laying the foundation for the *Buke* (warrior) regime centered in Kamakura in the days to come.

Fourth, the geopolitical situation of the Japanese archipelago also favored the unfolding of **feudalization**.

First, simply by opening a map, one can notice that the entire archipelago extends from southwest to northeast in a long and narrow shape. The straight-line distance from the southernmost part of Kyushu to the northernmost part of Honshu is nearly 1,500 kilometers.

If we draw a circle with such a radius centered on Xi'an or Luoyang, almost all the core ruling areas of China would be included within the circle. If we draw the same circle centered on Shiraz, modern Iran and Iraq would be entirely within it. If centered on Patna, the vast majority of the Indian subcontinent (excluding the southernmost tip) would fall inside this circle.

This fully demonstrates that the diameter of the Japanese archipelago posed a massive challenge to regime administration itself, and the mountainous terrain made this challenge even greater.

Although Japan, as an island nation, is no stranger to seafaring, the sea conditions in the Western Pacific are extremely complex. The difficulty of connecting the archipelago via maritime navigation is far beyond comparison with the Mediterranean, which has a long seafaring tradition.

In fact, as late as the Nanboku-chō (Northern and Southern Courts) period, when Prince Noriyoshi (义良亲王 / later Emperor Go-Murakami of the Southern Court) attempted to travel by sea between Yamato (大和) and Mutsu (陆奥), he was thwarted by storms. Once land routes were cut off, the Southern Court quickly lost control of Eastern Japan.

Corresponding to the narrow and long shape of the country is the unidirectional nature of its foreign interactions. Although Hokkaido had direct exchanges with what is now the Russian Far East across the sea during the Neolithic era, for Japan up until the *Chūsei* (中世 / Middle Ages), the vast majority of technology, wealth, and personnel came from the West—first through the Korean Peninsula, and later through direct interactions with China.

This also meant that internal economic development in Japan was uneven. Overall, the level of social development and **productive forces** (生产力) gradually declined from west to east, because advanced technologies invariably first appeared in the west and required time to spread eastward.

The plains suitable for population agglomeration in Japan are sparsely distributed along the coast. Among them, the largest—the Kanto Plain (关东平原)—happens to be located in eastern Japan. However, considering historical reasons and environmental factors (especially logistics), the ruling center of the *Ritsuryō* state was established in Kyoto, in western Japan.

The dispersion of local power and the uneven development across regions made it extremely difficult for Japan to form a centralized, extractive capital like Beijing—which relies on a massive continuous plain and the Grand Canal to suppress and extract from the entire nation. Local autonomy was much greater, and the court had to allow localities to exercise subjective initiative to maintain rule over the whole country.

Another thing that left a profound impression on me previously was when I looked at the distribution map of the circum-Pacific seismic belt (the Ring of Fire). I was surprised to find that although practically the entire nation of Japan is "unfortunately hit," Kyoto happens to be located precisely in a gap. In a country as prone to natural disasters as Japan, this can be called a haven of peace.

I deduce that once these special natural conditions combined with Japanese mythology, it ultimately formed the ideology that the emperor and the place where he resides (Kyoto) are pure and sacred, while the further away one gets, the more polluted it becomes, and lands outside Japan are realms of filth.

Consequently, the Kinki (近畿) region represented by Kyoto and Osaka was known in Japan as "*Kamigata*" (上方), while the Kanto region was disparagingly referred to as the rustic countryside

(田野乡间). This remained true even into the **early modern** (近世) Edo period, when Edo had actually become Japan's political center.

The Kanto *Samurai* also harbored this mindset. When Hōjō Yasutoki (北条泰时), the *Shikken* (执权 / Regent) of the Kamakura Shogunate, was compiling the *Goseibai Shikimoku* (《御成敗式目》 / Formulary of Adjudications), he expressed in a letter to his brother that this newborn *Buke* legal code might be mocked by the people of Kyoto as the laws of rustic villagers.

However, from another perspective, this arrogance from the "*Kamigata*" also made it difficult for the Japanese court to control the entire nation. The *Kuge* (公卿) would barely leave Kyoto a few times in their entire lives. As for the emperor, excluding situations like the Nanboku-chō period or being exiled by the *Samurai*, it was even more impossible.

Even at the dawn of the Meiji Restoration, when the young Meiji Emperor saw the Pacific Ocean with his own eyes for the first time en route from Kyoto to Tokyo, his companion Kido Takayoshi (木户孝允) was moved to tears, because an emperor had not seen the open sea for several centuries!

Kyoto itself was known as "easy to attack, hard to defend." This is not so much regarding its topography, but rather that the city was overwhelmingly dependent on logistical inputs. Even if an army occupied the city, if the logistics network was severed by the enemy, they would have to evacuate Kyoto. Such events occurred several times during the Nanboku-chō period.

The court lacked both interest in and understanding of places far from Kyoto and Osaka, yet it could not suppress the entire nation relying solely on the *Kinai* (畿内 / capital region). Even if it genuinely wanted to construct a bureaucratic centralized despotic polity like China's, it was geopolitically exceedingly difficult.

Thus, the rise of the *Samurai*, particularly their rise in the Kanto region, was unstoppable. On the one hand, they expanded production and accumulated strength in Kanto; on the other hand, they fortified their military power and political organization during their wars against the Emishi, ultimately growing into the mainstay of Japan's feudal revolution.

However, no matter how many favorable conditions exist, ultimate success depends on human agency. One of the simplest things in the world is finding rationales for events that have already occurred. People will never obtain a precise answer as to how much decisive significance these favorable conditions ultimately possessed.

We can even imagine: if China's **feudalization** (封建化) had ultimately been able to proceed normally, how many "factors favorable to China's **feudalization**" could have been found?

For example, the four favorable conditions for Japan's **feudalization** I just identified all refer to the early and middle stages of this process. In the final stage of Japan's **feudalization**—namely, the transition period from Japan's Sengoku (Warring States) period to the **early modern society** (近世社会)—another extremely important favorable factor emerged: the soaring production of precious metals within Japan.

The sharp increase in the circulation of gold and silver stimulated the vitality of the **commodity economy** (商品经济), allowing new cities, wealthy merchants (*Gōshō* / 豪商), and autonomous townsmen (*Chōnin* / 町人) to confidently step onto the historical stage. This forged the Oda-Toyotomi (*Shokuhō* / 织丰) regime, which was vastly more powerful than previous *Daimyos*,

ultimately creating the socio-economic conditions that led to the complete disintegration of the manors (*Shōen*).

Undoubtedly, the circulation of gold and silver favored Japanese society's rapid transition from the "Sengoku Daimyo **feudal society** (封建社会)" of the final 100 years of the *Chūsei* (Middle Ages) to the "Edo **early modern society**".

But this by no means implies that every Japanese person, or every Japanese ruler, was able to realize this factor, utilize it, and promote it.

The historical fact is that Toyotomi Hideyoshi (丰臣秀吉), who ultimately completed the great enterprise of pacifying the realm upon the foundation laid by Oda Nobunaga (织田信长), was precisely such a ruler who grasped the pulse of the era and adeptly utilized the power of merchants and commoners.

After securing the realm, he utilized the power derived from urban construction and gold/silver currency to complete various policies represented by the *Taikō Kenchi* (太阁检地 / Taikō's land surveys). These consolidated land possession as well as the master-vassal system and *Chigyō* (知行 / enfeoffment) system mediated by land, rectifying the chaotic state of land property rights nationwide.

It is precisely the combination of the complete maturation of the feudal system and the development of the **urban economy** (城市经济) that constitutes the cornerstone of an **early modern society** in the general sense.

Therefore, we must say that the development of Japanese society since the Middle Ages provided the *possibility* for precious metals to drive social progress, while heroic figures like Toyotomi Hideyoshi turned this into reality through their own struggles.

One point that should not be ignored is that there are many countries and regions worldwide famous for their abundant production of gold and silver, yet none managed to create an enterprise surpassing Japan's.

The fact is, although China was not inherently rich in gold and silver, the volume of silver imported since the Longqing (隆庆) era of the Ming Dynasty was undeniably massive. However, the development of the **commodity economy** in the late Ming ultimately failed to propel China into modern civilization.

The Samurai stood at the forefront of the historical torrent of Japan's **feudalization**, composing immortal feats. Throughout Asia, they can be deemed the "most revolutionary" class; their subjective initiative (主观能动性 / human agency) absolutely cannot be ignored.

2, 日本历史上存在哪些有利于封建化的因素

关于武士崛起并夺取政权的历程，日本学者研究已极为详尽，我在此基础上在此记录我所认为的，日本的封建化进程中出现了哪些有利的因素。

第一，日本虽然早早引进了来自中国的复辟官僚体制，但是对日本而言实在是太早了，天皇并没有条件去发挥这套专制政体真正的威力，因为当年日本的氏族贵族依然有力，远非阶级交替阶段的衰残之景。这就意味着，天皇在国家政治中的实际权力必然受到官僚化的贵族所制约，最能代表这种局面的莫过于平安时代中期的“摄关政治”。如此一来，日本天皇尽管试图以中国的体制来增强自己的权力，但

其专制色彩（至少在我作为一个中国人的视角）实在太淡了。专制与官僚是彼此联系紧密的两个概念，专制统治者为了加强其专制权力，就离不开一套复杂的官僚制度来收买、分化和压制可能产生威胁的阶层；而官僚体制愈是强大（在中国人看来，也就是一个纯粹“官本位”的社会），专制权力就愈发强大。这件事情在中国非常好理解，因为权力只对其来源负责，而官僚社会中成员的社会经济地位高度依赖于其在官僚体制内的位置，且其权力来源于上级，那么一层一层向上看，国家权力就必然被把控在极少数人手里。古代日本的天皇既然没有那么强专制色彩，那么日本的官僚体制也就弱化了，因为日本人没有必要像中国人一样，最终对皇帝一个人负责。日本的律令制改革不仅仅扩大了天皇的权力，以藤原氏为代表的有力氏族凭借官僚体制内的扩张同样扩大了其在全国的利益，这也就意味着律令制改革并非仅君主一方得利。事实上，很多人在观察日本的时候仅仅看到了天皇“万世一系”，却很容易忽视按家格决定其位阶的公卿也一直伴随天皇制度始终。于是天皇就不可能像中国的同行一样凌驾于万民之上“一言以决天下事”，他虽然被赋予了无与伦比的神性，但在现实政治中不过是“贵族中的贵族”，众多贵族中级别最高的那一个。天皇和贵族公卿之间仍然存在竞争对抗的关系，这为武士崛起创造了相对友好的环境，武士非但不会在一开始就成为众矢之的，而且还能左右逢源以壮大自身。（这里必须强调虽然日本平安时期和中国的南朝看起来都是贵族占重要地位的王朝国家，但本质截然不同，平安时期的贵族来源于阶级分化以来最初形成的氏族贵族，但江左六朝的所谓贵族本身就是封建化以来形成的大土地主，中国的氏族贵族已经在秦汉之际被基本消灭了）

由于缺乏强有力的专制历史，日本人就非常在意“公论”，这种在决策时采取合议的惯性显然有利于封建化的展开。我在看平安一朝的历史时，有一件事情给我留下了深刻的印象，那就是日本人总是一板一眼地去考虑某件事务的权责，这对于我这样一个长期官僚统治下社会中生活的居民来说是难以想象的。虽然历朝历代的官方律法并非毫不讲究权利和义务的对等，但是在中国，谁把原则真正当一回事？就是现在的新闻中，如“有关部门”这样模棱两可的说法依然大行其道，而无数亿生灵竟然多不以为怪。权力和责任清晰对等明明应该是政治上首要的原则之一，但是一旦权力集中在个别专制者手里，那么即使最简单的逻辑都能令人明白这个原则必然不可能被执行了。因为就算一个人能够行使的权力没有上限，他所能承担的责任也总是有限的，中国的皇帝念叨着“万方有罪，罪在朕躬”，崇祯皇帝朱由检亡国之前的17年里下了六次罪己诏，可是他们不要说真的惩罚自己，就是依旧我行我素又有谁能如何？于是在中华帝国的最后岁月里，权力越来越集中在上，而责任则越来越被分摊于下，说好处的时候老百姓就不见了，谈代价的时候一个人也少不了，这就是专制官僚极权发展到一定程度必然产生的事情。当平安中期日本朝廷的征税逻辑发生转变之时，权利和义务竟然如此顺畅和明确地落到受领和负名的身上，这在我看来真的不可思议。可见在日本，官僚制度并未破坏政治的基本原则，这也减轻了武士夺取政权所需要面临的困难。

第二，律令国家的兴亡与日本自身的历史进程存在明显的时差，这就是刚才提到的典型意义的古典日本其实仅仅是平安时期晚期的院政时代，而在院政作为一种政治模式走上历史舞台的公元11世纪末，日本的律令制实际上早就名存实亡了。我虽然对武士的功业采取一种极为赞许的态度，但是不得不承认，虽然“武士在封建革命中击败了贵族官僚”这句话在形式上是对的，然而具体来说迫使律令体制走向末路的并非武士，武士的崛起要晚于律令制的瓦解。其中的逻辑并不复杂，律令制之所以诞生在中国，本身就是君主和官僚体制应对封建领主的应激反应，即使作为官僚制度的一种它自己也不成熟，甚至本身就不可能不具有封建化时代的一些特征，就如刚才说过的政府直接掌握并分配生产资料（均田制）。这种天真的幻想一旦移植到日本形势就变得更为怪异，现在日本的朝廷也要实施公民公地制，但是其所处的社会发展阶段根本无法像唐朝一样产生足够的能令政策运转的脱产官僚。不管一个政策看起来多么威力无穷，其落到实处总归是要经于人手，而在公元七、八世纪，日本国内能够形式上完成这一工作的也就是藤原氏那样的有力贵族。既然分配生产资料这一工作不得不由这些有力贵族才能完成，那么朝廷或者说天皇想要阻止他们侵占土地根本就是不可能的事情。在这种局面下，律令国家实际上加速了封建庄园的形成和扩张，而皇室、贵族和寺社的庄园数目庞大、分布广泛，这些高贵的庄园主既没有意愿也不可能去进行管理和维护。武士则作为为这些贵胄名刹们处理庄园事务的人走上舞台，因而当武士走向历史前台的时候，他们的身份是当权者的合作者而非对抗者，这一点是极其值得注意的。虽然武士最终以日本的封建领主这一身份为后人所铭记，但是在日本最初能够被称为封建主的人，或许就是那些在历史长河中最终被武士取代的庄园主。

第三，在整个平安时期，日本的外部地缘形势对封建化十分有利。唐帝国于安史之乱之后疲于应付逐渐崩溃的边疆形势和脱离控制的藩镇，已经对日本造不成任何现实的威胁。等到宋朝建立，官僚体制进一步巩固的结果是，现在中华帝国的人民取代了任何外族成为中国统治者最大的假想敌，这种变化在外交领域就体现在政策的逐渐保守上，帝国已经不可能再像汉唐时期那样频繁地对外发动干涉和扩张战争。自从渤海国以来，中国的东北地区经济得到进一步发展，新兴少数民族政权不断建立或者扩张到达此处，与向北扩张的朝鲜政权相冲突，朝鲜人也不得不把军事重心放到北方。这些形式的变化对于日本这一孤悬海外的列岛国家来说无疑意味着军事压力的极大减轻，从而为平安时期“中外无事”的大裁军提供了条件。天下承平的局面不但使得维护律令国家对于人力和财富的汲取变得毫无理由，也将国内“治安战争”的任务交给了新兴武士。然而这种低战争烈度并非完全没有战争，在平安时代的大部分时间日本都一直在加强对东北地区的控制，征讨虾夷作为一个长期工作存在。站在事后的角度来看，虾夷作为日本政权的对手其力量实在是太恰到好处了，它既没有强大到需要足够的军事动员能力才能够击败，又没有弱小到等闲几十上百个开拓民就能如入无人之境。如果要应对同虾夷的战争，那么日本朝廷最为有效和低成本的选择便是倚仗武士。对于武士而言，虾夷人既没有强大到根本不能战胜或者为了取胜会付出过大的代价，也没有弱小到只需要一场武装游行就可宣告开学。事实是，武士在同虾夷人的战争中得到了充分历练，不仅在战斗技术上向对方学习，例如后来大名鼎鼎的武士刀就发展于虾夷人的武器。而且就是在长期的战斗中，属于武士的主从关系以及源氏作为“武家栋梁”的威望树立起来了。也就是在战争中，基于土地的恩赏开始形成，武士的自我意识抬头。在以关东和东北为中心的国内战争和征夷战争中，地方武士团的势力不断扩大，这奠定了日后以镰仓为中心武家政权的基石。

第四，日本列岛的地缘形势也有利于封建化的展开。首先打开地图就能注意到的一点是整个列岛自西南向东北方向延伸，形状狭长，从九州岛的最南部到本州岛的最北部直线距离接近 1500 公里。以西安或者洛阳为中心画如此半径的一个圆，那么几乎中国所有核心统治区域都包括在圆内；以设拉子

（Shiraz）为中心画如此半径的一个圆，那么现在的伊朗和伊拉克完全都在圆内；以巴特那（Patna）为中心画如此半径的一个圆，那么现在印度次大陆除最南端外绝大部分地区都在这个圆内。这充分说明日本列岛的直径对于政权管理本身具有挑战，列岛多山的地形使得这个挑战更大了。虽然日本作为一个岛国对于航海并不陌生，但是西太平洋的海况极为复杂，想要通过海上航行来连接列岛的难度远非有悠久航海传统的地中海可比。事实上一直到南北朝时期，義良亲王（后来日本南朝的后村上天皇）想要从海上往返于大和与陆奥之间就为风暴所阻，一旦陆路不得交通，南朝很快就失去了对东日本的控制。与狭长的国土形状相对应的是对外交往的单向性，虽说在新石器时代北海道也与对岸的今天，俄国远东地区有直接交流，但是对直到中世的日本而言，技术、财富和人员中的绝大多数都来自西方，先是通过朝鲜半岛，然后是直接与中国交流。这也就意味着在日本内部经济发展也是不均衡的，从整体上从西向东社会发展水平和生产力水平逐渐下降，这是因为先进技术往往新出现在西部，向东传播尚需时日。日本国内适合人口聚集的平原零星地分布在海边，其中最大的关东平原恰好位于日本东部，而律令国家的统治中心考虑到历史原因和环境因素（特别是物流）设在西日本的京都。地方权力的分散和各地发展的不平衡使得日本很难形成北京那样的依托大块平原以及京杭运河对全国各地进行压制和汲取的集权首都，各地方的自主性要大很多，朝廷也不得不令其发挥主观能动性才能维持对全国的统治。

还有在以前就给留下深刻印象的一件事是，当我以前看环太平洋火山地震带分布图，惊讶地发现虽然日本全国基本上都“不幸中招”，但是京都恰好就处于一个间断点上，这在日本这样一个自然灾害频发的国家堪称安乐乡。我推测这种特殊的自然条件一旦与日本的神话传说相结合，就会最终形成天皇及天皇所居之地（京都）是纯洁神圣的，而离此越远则越为污浊，日本之外则是污秽之地了这样的思想。如此一来，京都大阪为代表的近畿地区在日本被称为“上方”，而关东地区则被贬称为田野乡间，甚至直到近世的江户时期，江户实际上成为日本的政治中心时仍然如此。关东的武士也存在这样的思想，镰仓幕府的执权北条泰时在编定《御成败式目》时，给兄弟的信中也表示新生的武家法典可能被京都的人们嘲笑为田野村夫的法律。然而从另一个方面讲，这种来自“上方”的傲慢也使得日本朝廷难以控制全国，公卿一辈子也不会离开京都几次，至于天皇除了南北朝这样的情况以及被武士流放就更不可能了。甚至于到了明治维新伊始，年纪轻轻的明治天皇在从京都前往东京的途中第一次亲眼看见了太平洋，同行的木户孝允甚至落泪，因为天皇已经有数个世纪不曾见过外海了。京都本身被称为“易攻难守”，这更多不是从地势上来说，而是说这座城市实在太依赖于物流输入，就算军队占据了城市而物流网络被敌人掐断，那么也不得不退出京都，这样的事情在南北朝发生过数次。朝廷对于远离京坂的地方既缺乏兴

趣和了解，又不能仅凭借畿内就压制全国，就算真的想构建出像中国一样的官僚制专制主义中央集权政体在地缘上也是难上加难。那么武士的崛起，特别是在关东地方的崛起，就是难以阻止的了，他们一面在关东扩大生产积蓄力量，一面在与虾夷人作战的过程中强化了军事力量和政治组织，最终成长为日本封建革命的中流砥柱。

然而，无论有多少有利条件，成事最终还是在人。世界上最简单的事情之一莫过于为已经发生的事情寻找合理性，这些有利条件最终有多少决定意义，人们永远也不会得到一个精确的答案。我们甚至可以想象如果中国的封建化最终得以正常进行下去，那么又能找到多少“有利于中国封建化的因素”呢？例如我刚刚寻找的四条日本封建化的有利条件都是指对于封建化的前中阶段有利，而在日本封建化的最后阶段，也就是日本战国向近世社会过渡的时期也出现了一个非常重要的有利因素，那就是日本国内贵金属产量的飙升。金银流通量的急剧增大刺激了商品经济的活跃，使得新的都市，豪商与自治的町人自信地登上历史舞台，塑造了比以往大名更加强有力的织丰政权，最终创造了使得庄园彻底瓦解的社会经济条件。毫无疑问，金银的流通有利于日本社会得以从中世的最后 100 年间“战国大名的封建社会”迅速转向“江户的近世社会”。

但是这绝不是说每一个日本人，或者说每一个日本的统治者都能够意识到这一因素并利用和促进它。历史的事实便是，在织田信长基础上最终完成天下平定伟业的丰臣秀吉就是这样一个摸准了时代脉搏，善用商人与百姓之力的统治者。而在他取得天下之后，又利用来自都市建设和金银货币的力量，完成了以太阁检地为代表的各项政策巩固了以土地占有和以土地为媒介的主从制、知行制，整治了全国范围内土地产权混乱的情况。正是封建制度的完全成熟和城市经济发展两点相结合，构成了一般而言近世社会的基石。因此我们不得不说，中世以来日本社会的发展为贵金属能够对于社会进步起到推动作用的可能，而像丰臣秀吉这样的英雄人物凭借自己的奋斗将其变为现实。不应该忽视的一点是，全世界以盛产金银而著称的国家和地区很多，然而没有哪一个能够创造超越日本的事业。事实就是，尽管中国并非盛产金银，但是明朝自隆庆以来输入的白银数量不可谓不巨大，但是明末商品经济的发展最终也没有使得中国进入近代文明。武士在日本封建化的历史洪流中立于潮头，谱写了不朽的功勋，在整个亚洲都堪称是“最为革命”的阶级，他们的主观能动性是完全无法忽视的。